

Chapter 59-1

Chen Liuying, who had just finished her filming work, returned to her dressing room. Her assistant handed her a cup of warm water.

She gulped down a few sips, then frowned: "What did you put in the water?"

"Honey," the assistant said tremulously. "Sister Weiwei told me to add it—it's good for your throat."

"Too sweet." Chen Liuying put down the cup and said coldly: "Don't add these random things to the water in the future."

"But Sister Weiwei..." The assistant was about to explain when Chen Liuying interrupted: "You're my assistant, not Bai Weiwei's. Understand?"

The overwhelming oppressive aura frightened the assistant into shivering, and she immediately said: "I understand."

"Give me my phone." Chen Liuying extended her hand toward her. The assistant immediately rummaged through her bag to find her phone, but hesitated when handing it over, looking at Chen Liuying with hesitation.

Chen Liuying thought the new assistant was a bit stupid, far inferior to the previous one.

But the previous one had been too beautiful and was targeted by Bai Weiwei until she couldn't continue working and resigned.

Now she had this one with average looks who wasn't efficient at work either. Chen Liuying found her annoying just looking at her.

She had always liked beautiful things.

For example—Xu Qingzhu.

But someone like that wasn't someone she could covet. She couldn't get past Bai Weiwei alone.

Previously, she had thought Bai Weiwei was beautiful, capable at work, and most importantly, aloof and abstinent¹. But after pursuing her, she discovered... it was all an illusion.

In reality, she was possessive, petty and selfish, sharp-tongued yet loved to pretend to be generous.

Chen Liuying was getting a bit tired of her too.

But unfortunately, Bai Weiwei was quite a capable agent. Currently, all the business in her hands had to go through Bai Weiwei. Before she developed to the stage of being hugely popular, she couldn't change agents.

Of course, she also couldn't break up.

Actually, she used to quite like Bai Weiwei—rich family's daughter, strong work ability, and when they played together she could usually learn without a teacher. At first she was shy, but later in bed, the two were very compatible.

But ever since the Huayue International incident was exposed, Bai Weiwei had become increasingly anxious, and her possessiveness had become excessively strong. Her personal time and space were constantly being squeezed, making her feel suffocated.

Today was rare—she came out to film and Bai Weiwei didn't follow.

Probably because they had argued a few words yesterday, and Bai Weiwei was somewhat angry.

After all, she was also a rich family's daughter. While not extremely wealthy, she lived comfortably and had smooth sailing.

Those few sentences like "look at what you've become now," "don't stop being my agent just because you became my girlfriend," and "can't you even do your basic job properly" probably hurt Miss Bai's self-esteem, so today she was given free space.

Chen Liuying's mind recalled yesterday's events while her hands had already unlocked her phone.

More rarely, Bai Weiwei hadn't sent her any messages today.

If it were usual, she would have sent more than ten messages asking about her filming situation and progress.

Her sudden coldness made Chen Liuying somewhat unaccustomed.

So she looked up and asked her assistant: "Did Bai Weiwei contact you?"

"Does asking about your filming progress count?" the assistant replied in a low voice.

This was Bai Weiwei alright.

Chen Liuying's heart settled back into her stomach. She then considered what gift to send Bai Weiwei to coax her into a good mood—her career could only be long-lasting that way.

Every time it came to this, Chen Liuying would feel a flash of regret in her heart. Why had she started dating her own agent back then?

The other party held her weaknesses and fatal vulnerabilities. Breaking up wouldn't be easy.

But Bai Weiwei was indeed the most manageable and high-quality target she could handle currently.

Others would have to wait until her status was higher before she could reach them.

By then, she would definitely coax Bai Weiwei into breaking up.

For her, Bai Weiwei didn't meet the standards for marriage.

Chen Liuying went to a shopping app to search for small gifts, casually placed an order for one item, then exited. Just as she was about to switch to Weibo, she noticed her assistant looking at her with hesitation.

Chen Liuying frowned: "Is there something else?"

"No..." the assistant looked at her timidly, then after a moment said: "Sort of..."

Before she could finish speaking, production staff knocked on the door: "Teacher Chen, we need you to reshoot one more scene. Could you come again?"

Chen Liuying's attitude toward production staff was relatively good, and she immediately said: "Alright, coming."

After saying this, she turned off her phone, threw it to her assistant, and said somewhat impatiently: "If there's something to say, say it. If there's nothing, don't hem and haw."

Chen Liuying glanced at her sideways: "It's annoying to watch."

The assistant was frightened into trembling and immediately said: "I understand."

She didn't dare say anything more.

The subsequent reshooting was just two scenes, but they were extremely demanding of camera presence.

But for someone who was beautiful and had no bad angles from any of 360 degrees, camera presence was something that existed naturally. So Chen Liuying's reshooting went very smoothly. But what puzzled her was that everyone on the filming set was looking at her with hesitation.

Those gazes contained intense curiosity and scrutiny.

Chen Liuying was already accustomed to being watched by everyone, but she could still easily distinguish between appreciation and scrutiny.

It wasn't until she finished reshooting that her assistant handed her warm water without any additives.

Author Notes: ¹ Abstinent: In Chinese web novel context, refers to someone who appears sexually restrained or emotionally distant, often seen as an attractive quality

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After drinking a few sips, Chen Liuying looked at her assistant: "Is there something on my face?"

"No." The assistant immediately denied.

"Then why are they all looking at me?" Chen Liuying asked.

The assistant: "..."

After a brief silence, the assistant said tremblingly: "You should probably open Weibo and take a look."

Chen Liuying raised an eyebrow: "Do I have negative trending topics?"

The assistant pressed her lips together: "Should... probably not..."

Chen Liuying was too lazy to listen to her stammering nonsense and directly opened Weibo.

At that time it was evening, and she saw her name tied together with the Minghui Jewelry heiress, her brow immediately furrowing deeply.

She quickly browsed through the trending topics and the public square, then opened her own Weibo backend to see that not long ago, this account had just posted an ambiguous Weibo post.

...

Without even thinking, she knew it was Bai Weiwei's doing.

The video from that day in the restroom had been exposed, and she had gotten the Changli endorsement.

Right now she was still hanging in high position on trending topics being pitied by netizens, her Weibo followers were still increasing, but somehow she felt uneasy in her heart. Most importantly, when Bai Weiwei did all these things, she kept her completely in the dark!

Chen Liuying was so angry her face changed. She grabbed her coat and walked outside, telling her assistant: "Back to the company."

And as she walked outside, she could still hear passersby discussing this matter.

"Chen Liuying got beaten? She looks arrogant and domineering—more like she'd be the one beating people."

"What are you talking about? The one who beat her is the Dongheng young madam. I heard the Liang family's third miss isn't someone to mess with. She dared to touch someone else's wife? Does she want to be blacklisted?"

"You're right. Actors are just actors after all."

"Sigh, the entertainment industry is originally just a plaything for capitalists. Chen Liuying can only act tough in small circles—how dare she try to climb higher?"

"Last time her agent had trouble, it seemed like it was to pull resources for her. In the end, money is where power lies."

"Exactly. In front of capital, Chen Liuying is just a dog. What's so strange about her getting beaten?"

"..."

At that time, Chen Liuying and her assistant were standing in the elevator, and the elevator doors slowly closed.

The assistant felt as if a layer of ice had formed in the elevator, frightening her legs to tremble, not daring to look at Chen Liuying.

And Chen Liuying clenched her fists, so angry she was about to explode.

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Chen Liuying returned to Jingyi Culture at the fastest speed.

As soon as she reached the seventh floor, company employees kept greeting her, but she ignored everyone with a sour face and walked straight toward Bai Weiwei's office.

She didn't even knock on the door, directly pushing it open to enter.

Bai Weiwei was on the phone with someone: "Lead the narrative toward Minghui's side again. Make sure to ruin their reputation. Wasn't there news before about Minghui Jewelry's inferior products causing skin allergies? Bring that up together. Anyway, make this water as muddy as possible."

"Bang—"

A loud crash startled Bai Weiwei, who had her back to the door. She turned around, saw it was Chen Liuying, and said into the phone: "Just go ahead and do it."

Only then did she hang up.

"What are you doing?" Chen Liuying demanded sternly: "Who gave you permission to log into my Weibo?"

"You saw everything." Bai Weiwei sat down expressionlessly, then used her hand to operate the mouse, clicking a few times before seeing Chen Liuying's Weibo backend data. The follower count was still continuously climbing. Under her arrangement of having marketing accounts lead the narrative, Chen Liuying's reputation and public opinion were constantly reversing, with online praise everywhere.

She turned the computer to face Chen Liuying, confidently raising an eyebrow: "When have I ever harmed you?"

Chen Liuying looked at her, almost gritting her teeth as she questioned: "I'm asking you why you logged into my Weibo without my permission?"

Bai Weiwei frowned: "You were filming."

"So you can post these things without my consent?" Chen Liuying asked: "Do you know that if Xu Qingzhu exposes this, my career will be over?"

"Expose what?" Bai Weiwei suddenly asked: "What happened in the restroom that day?"

Chen Liuying suddenly froze, and her momentum weakened by three points.

"So that day in the restroom, you really did lay hands on Xu Qingzhu?" Bai Weiwei slammed the table and stood up: "Chen Liuying, you're..."

"I didn't!" Before Bai Weiwei could go berserk, Chen Liuying first defended herself. She said coldly: "Why are you suspecting me again? I already explained this to you before. I just went up to say a few words to her, wanted her to reconcile with you, and even apologized for what happened at the hospital before. She was the one who got emotional and struck first."

The office was so quiet you could hear a pin drop.

After a moment, Bai Weiwei exhaled lightly, but still asked with disbelief: "Really?"

These two words instantly touched Chen Liuying's sensitive nerves, and she shouted angrily: "You don't believe me again?"

"I believe you." Bai Weiwei sat down again. She tucked her disheveled hair behind her ear and calmed her slightly agitated emotions before saying to Chen Liuying: "So we have nothing to fear. People must pay for their actions."

"But you and she are friends." Chen Liuying said: "I know you care about her a lot, so I don't want you to become enemies with her because of me. Wouldn't that make me the sinner?"

Bai Weiwei sneered. She turned her chair to look out the window: "You're right. I treated her as a friend, but she never treated me as one."

"Why did you release that thing?" Chen Liuying frowned: "And now that things have blown up this big, what exactly are you trying to do?"

Another endless silence.

After the silence, Bai Weiwei let out a cold laugh. Her voice, devoid of any warmth, rang out in the office, enunciating each word: "I want her to be utterly ruined."

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Chen Liuying frowned, thinking about what happened in the restroom that day, and still felt uneasy.

What if Xu Qingzhu had a recording from that day, or if there were surveillance cameras outside? Once that was made public, the consequences would be unimaginable.

Thinking of this, Chen Liuying spoke up: "Haven't you considered that Xu Qingzhu might retaliate?"

"So what if she retaliates?" Bai Weiwei said: "I'm the one with the video, she's the one who hit someone. There were only the three of us in the restroom that day, and she has no leverage in her hands."

Bai Weiwei curved her lips into a smile: "This time, she has no chance of winning."

"But behind her is all of Dongheng." Chen Liuying frowned: "Wouldn't it be easy for them to destroy us?"

"So what about Dongheng? It's not like they can cover the sky with one hand." Bai Weiwei sneered: "Now that things have blown up, everyone is watching. Would Dongheng dare to do something against the law? They wouldn't dare. And I've already helped you secure the Changli endorsement. This time should be a significant milestone in your career."

Chen Liuying still felt guilty listening to this: "How do you know she has no chance of winning?"

Bai Weiwei played the recording of Xu Qingzhu's phone call to Chen Liuying, then said: "Based on my understanding of her, she can't stand being wrongly accused the most. So if she had evidence in her hands, she would immediately release it for the public to see, to prove her innocence."

"But it's already been an entire afternoon, and she only called me to question me, which means she has no leverage." Bai Weiwei said: "She probably wanted to fish information out of me, but what use is that? I wouldn't be caught by someone who hasn't even entered society yet."

Bai Weiwei spoke with absolute confidence, but Chen Liuying felt something was wrong.

But she couldn't pinpoint exactly what was wrong.

Seeing her still thinking, Bai Weiwei immediately reassured her: "Don't worry. If it weren't absolutely safe, I wouldn't drag you into this. I logged into your Weibo account to add more fuel to this fire."

Chen Liuying frowned: "Didn't you promise me last time that you wouldn't log into my Weibo account anymore?"

"This is business." Bai Weiwei said: "Do we need to make such clear distinctions between us about everything?"

Chen Liuying was momentarily speechless.

Anger had consumed her rationality, preventing her from calming down enough to think of words to placate Bai Weiwei, so she could only remain silent.

Bai Weiwei thought she was still angry and immediately sat on her lap, taking her hand and hooking it gently, obediently coaxing: "Don't be angry anymore. This time I not only helped you get the Changli endorsement, but Director Liu's next drama also plans to use you as the female lead."

Chen Liuying still had that sour face.

Bai Weiwei pressed her lips together and leaned in to kiss her, but Chen Liuying just turned her face away.

Bai Weiwei's movement paused, and she suddenly asked: "Do you have some kind of leverage that fell into Xu Qingzhu's hands?"

"How is that possible?" Chen Liuying immediately denied: "I'm not even familiar with her."

But irritation showed in her eyes and brows.

She always felt uneasy, as if something was going to happen.

But she couldn't tell Bai Weiwei, so she could only confirm with her once more: "You're sure Xu Qingzhu didn't have a recording or anything that day, right?"

"She was standing with you the whole time. When would she have had time to record?" Bai Weiwei said: "And there were only the three of us in that restroom. I didn't even hear clearly what you two said. As long as we stick to this story, no one will believe her. You've been in the industry for almost a year now. How do you not even know this?"

"I know." Chen Liuying said: "But..."

She hesitated, and Bai Weiwei immediately became alert: "Did you really do something in that restroom that day?"

"I already said I didn't." Chen Liuying was also annoyed: "Why are you always so paranoid?"

Bai Weiwei pressed her lips together, doubt and hurt flashing in her eyes.

"I just think there's a problem with what you're doing." Chen Liuying frowned.

Before she could finish speaking, Bai Weiwei said: "Do you like Xu Qingzhu?"

Chen Liuying: "..."

"No." Chen Liuying became increasingly irritated: "I've only met her a few times?"

Although... she did indeed admire Xu Qingzhu's beauty.

And the scent on her body.

Xu Qingzhu had a mixed scent of strawberries and wine that was intoxicating just to smell.

If she weren't married, Chen Liuying would really be quite interested.

But... even though she was married, Chen Liuying felt she could wait until the day she divorced.

After all, according to Bai Weiwei, Xu Qingzhu and the Liang family's third miss were just in a business marriage and would definitely divorce someday.

Chen Liuying was interested in plucking such a flower that had bloomed under someone else.

It should have a unique flavor.

But she could never say these words to Bai Weiwei.

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Bai Weiwei was already controlling enough, to the point where she could barely breathe.

She should really put breaking up with Bai Weiwei on the agenda.

If she continued making trouble like this, she would sooner or later be utterly ruined in this industry.

But she couldn't break up directly—Bai Weiwei would make a scene, and if it got too big, it wouldn't be good for her.

She still needed to coax her.

But Chen Liuying's patience was currently on the brink of exhaustion.

Even with Bai Weiwei sitting on her lap now, she had no sexual interest in playing the office games she used to love most.

She just felt annoyed.

"Then why do you care so much?" Bai Weiwei said: "I'm absolutely confident I can make her utterly ruined. And this is beneficial to you with no downsides. This afternoon, your Weibo gained 300,000 followers. Tonight is when traffic is at its best. After one night, you might gain a million followers. Tomorrow we can finalize that drama with Director Liu."

"Oh." Chen Liuying was disinterested, her mind full of thoughts about breaking up with Bai Weiwei.

But Bai Weiwei thought she was distracted and directly leaned in to kiss her. Gradually, desire was aroused, and all the day's exhaustion and irritation could be vented in an exhilarating session of sex.

Just as Chen Liuying was pressing Bai Weiwei onto the desk, the office door suddenly opened.

Bai Weiwei's arms were supporting her on the desk, her top shirt pushed halfway up.

Looking extremely disheveled.

The assistant saw this and cried out in shock, repeatedly apologizing, then closed the door.

Chen Liuying still wanted to continue, but Bai Weiwei immediately pulled down her clothes, saying in a low voice: "Let's do it at home tonight."

"Killjoy." Chen Liuying said coldly.

Bai Weiwei kissed her lips, straightened her clothes, and only then let the assistant come in: "What is it?"

The assistant's eyes darted around, wanting to speak but hesitating.

Bai Weiwei lost her patience: "What is it exactly?"

"You... you should check Weibo." The assistant's voice trembled: "That person tagged you."

Bai Weiwei frowned and immediately picked up her phone.

Only then did she see the Weibo post that Xu Qingzhu had posted.

—Are you all sure it was me who hit someone?

This question was asked so poorly, so lacking in substance.

It was like saying pitifully: I didn't hit anyone, you all just didn't see clearly.

Bai Weiwei laughed after seeing it. It seemed Xu Qingzhu had no leverage at all, so she could only use this method to refute. But what did netizens want?

Evidence!

Unfortunately, all the evidence was with her.

Bai Weiwei had originally worried she might have some clever tricks up her sleeve, but after seeing this Weibo post, she completely relaxed.

The current Xu Qingzhu was like a grasshopper after autumn¹—she wouldn't be jumping around for much longer.

She might as well send Xu Qingzhu off one more time.

Anyway, things had come to this point. There was no going back between them.

Bai Weiwei looked at that Weibo post. The comments section had already been quickly overrun.

Almost all of them were cursing her.

[Don't you know whether you hit someone or not?]

[Sister, the video has already been released. Are you still playing the white lotus² here?]

[OMG! I'm gonna puke! Your acting skills don't belong anywhere but the entertainment industry.]

[Don't gross me out, person above. The entertainment industry isn't a garbage dump.]

[...]

This was probably the first time Xu Qingzhu had been cursed at so much in her entire life.

She had grown up smoothly, pampered in a honey pot, never suffered any grievances. Because of her outstanding looks and excellent grades, she was an unreachable existence to others at school.

How could she have ever been cursed at like this?

Just scrolling through her Weibo comments gave Bai Weiwei a strange sense of pleasure.

And this pleasure made her lose her ability to think. At this moment, she only wanted to add another stroke to these curses.

So she logged into Chen Liuying's Weibo. Just as she was editing the text, Chen Liuying stopped her: "What are you doing?"

Bai Weiwei curved her lips into a smile and said confidently: "Making sure she dies completely."

A few minutes later, Chen Liuying and Bai Weiwei posted on Weibo simultaneously.

@Chen Liuying: The past is past, a better future lies ahead.

@Bai Weiwei: The video wasn't photoshopped or edited. Previously, I was too angry, so I vented to a good friend about this matter. I don't know how it leaked out, but since it appeared and blew up, I'll answer your question. If even videos are fake in this world, if even what I saw with my own eyes is fake, then what can we believe?

Footnotes:

¹ Grasshopper after autumn: A Chinese saying meaning someone whose time is running out, as grasshoppers die when autumn ends.

² White lotus: A term for someone who pretends to be innocent and pure while actually being manipulative or fake.

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The two people's Weibo posts were published simultaneously. One pretended to be magnanimous, the other was passive-aggressive and spoke with righteous indignation.

Bai Weiwei was willing to bear the infamy herself to shape Chen Liuying's online image well.

The deliberately crafted noble image for Chen Liuying was displayed vividly in this Weibo post. It looked very literary, but the underlying meaning was—you did hit someone, but I won't hold it against you. I hope you'll conduct yourself better in the future!

It must be said that in terms of public opinion rhetoric and understanding netizens' psychology, Bai Weiwei had grasped the essence.

She easily performed a feat of using four ounces to move a thousand pounds¹.

Now netizens loved Chen Liuying even more, and the speed of her follower growth was even faster than before.

At the same time, curses erupted online.

Before Xu Qingzhu spoke up, netizens had only been cursing Minghui Jewelry. Almost everyone was attacking Minghui Jewelry's official Weibo. But then Xu Qingzhu spoke up on Weibo.

Things immediately became lively. Everyone rushed to her Weibo to curse madly, especially Chen Liuying's fans, saying things like, "You're taking advantage of my sister's gentlemanly demeanor to hit people. You deserve to die."

The most vicious comments attacked Xu Qingzhu's entire family.

There were too many negative comments to read through all at once.

Sally, sitting in the office, looked at the private messages constantly popping up in the backend and exclaimed in shock: "They're really too vicious."

Liang Shi said: "Don't take it to heart. They're all just fence-sitters²."

"Are we still not going to strike now?" Lin Luoxi said: "At least release a lawyer's letter to show our stance and attitude. Netizens have already decided we're in the wrong."

"It's not time yet." Liang Shi glanced at the time: "Let the public opinion ferment a bit more."

Ten minutes after Bai Weiwei and Chen Liuying's Weibo posts went out, Liang Shi, controlling Xu Qingzhu's account, posted a second Weibo:

@Xu Qingzhu-Blanche: The video is certainly not fake, but why is there no audio track? Can my guilt be determined with just one image? Isn't this too arbitrary? There were only the three of us in the restroom that day. You recorded the video, so naturally you know what happened. So—why are you framing me? @Bai Weiwei.

And do you dare to step forward and openly say you have a clear conscience? Do you dare to tell everyone what really happened that day? @Chen Liuying.

Liang Shi's wording was rigorous and precise, giving people a sense of psychological oppression.

It also conveyed an attitude to the public—I didn't do it. You're framing me.

And the public would only say: If you have the ability, produce evidence. Don't just use words to manipulate people's emotions here.

But from Bai Weiwei's perspective, at this moment Xu Qingzhu was like a spent force³. She had no evidence, so she could do nothing but use pale words to threaten her, trying to gain the public's sympathy.

Bai Weiwei became even more unbridled and directly confronted her online.

@Bai Weiwei: As close friends, I naturally didn't want things to reach this point. You know better than I do what happened that day. Well-intentioned persuasion became malicious misinterpretation. Attempts to ease relations led us further apart due to your behavior. I wanted to say let's part amicably, but you won't let it go. Whether you're being wrongly accused or not, you know in your heart. People shouldn't forget others' human rights just because they have privilege.

Choosing to trend on a day like this, in this manner—is this what you wanted? I've always known some people would stop at nothing to achieve their goals, but I never imagined such methods would be used on me someday.

Chen Liuying's Weibo also posted:

@Chen Liuying: Let this matter pass. Stop wasting public resources.

In an instant, Xu Qingzhu became the villain who maliciously occupied public resources and would stop at nothing to achieve her goals.

It must be said that Bai Weiwei was masterful at implying things about others and throwing dirty water on them.

Everyone knew today was the day of Minghui Jewelry's autumn new product launch. On such a day, Xu Qingzhu's incident was exposed. Negative trending topics were still trending topics—that was still traffic!

Plus with Zhao Ying and Yang Shuyan's endorsements afterward, wasn't this exactly what Bai Weiwei meant by "stopping at nothing to achieve goals"?

Buy negative trending topics, then deliberately whitewash.

This was typical marketing, and it was marketing by stepping on Chen Liuying.

Good heavens.

In the fans' eyes, this was practically like dancing on Chen Liuying's grave!

So Chen Liuying's fans exploded!

Without caring about anything else, they went to attack Xu Qingzhu, cursing her to be worthless, wishing she'd be hit by a car that very day. They also cursed Zhao Ying and Yang Shuyan, saying they were taking dirty money and deserved to die.

These fans at this moment were a bunch of lunatics, cursing whoever they caught.

So online curses erupted in warfare, with several parties in chaotic battle.

Originally, Zhao Ying's and Yang Shuyan's fan groups were the two most antagonistic fan groups in the entertainment industry. But today, on this day that seemed like nothing special, they unexpectedly united and began surrounding Chen Liuying's fans.

As the saying goes, the enemy of my enemy is a friend.

So everyone witnessed the great unity of the entertainment industry that day.

In the countless days afterward, this incident became a strange tale of melon-eating⁴ for casual observers.

At its root, it was because Chen Liuying's fans were jumping too high and making too much noise.

Netizens weren't stupid either. Thinking it over, they realized Bai Weiwei had a point.

Who would want the entire internet to see themselves getting beaten for no reason?

Wouldn't that be indirectly saying they were useless?

And Chen Liuying had been maintaining a persona as "the internet's number one 御A⁵." This video had only been out for half a day, and people online were already making memes of Chen Liuying.

That GIF of her head hitting the wall was being used as an emoji, wildly parodied by netizens, and forwarded countless times.

It would probably become the biggest dark history since Chen Liuying's debut.

If it was to bring down Minghui Jewelry, the sacrifice for Chen Liuying seemed too great.

Moreover, there was no grudge between them.

Why would she go this far?

So now the person most likely to do this was Xu Qingzhu—that is, Minghui Jewelry.

Netizens who thought they understood the entire situation sorted out the overall logic of events and then said very "wisely": "This can be called a very successful self-hype event."

After all, all of Minghui Jewelry's goods had already become in a state of supply falling short of demand.

Anyone who saw it couldn't help but be convinced.

Even marketing major students sighed: "Which marketing expert is behind this company? This incident could be put in textbooks as a case study (if it doesn't end in failure)."

Netizens who had bought goods during the day also felt they'd been deceived and wanted to return their purchases.

But some people lived close to shopping malls and had already gotten the actual products from counters.

The real-life photos netizens posted showed that the viewing experience when worn was even better than the official website photos.

People who wanted returns really couldn't resist the temptation.

So while Minghui Jewelry's backend orders had some losses, they weren't severe.

And at this moment, as lights came on across the city, the entire city entered the slow pace of evening. In Minghui Jewelry's office, Liang Shi ordered crawfish and barbecue for everyone.

Everyone: "...???"

It must be said, crawfish and barbecue were still fragrant.

Even someone as aloof and noble as Zhou Yi'an, upon smelling the aroma, couldn't help but take gloves from the table and join everyone.

Footnotes:

¹ Using four ounces to move a thousand pounds: A Chinese idiom meaning to achieve great results with minimal effort.

² Fence-sitters: People who change their opinions easily based on circumstances; bandwagon followers.

³ Spent force: Translated from Chinese idiom meaning someone who has exhausted their strength or resources.

⁴ Melon-eating: Internet slang for watching drama unfold as a spectator; being entertained by others' conflicts.

⁵ 御A: A type of Alpha personality in ABO dynamics, specifically one who is commanding and dominant yet maintains composure and elegance.

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Xu Qingzhu, however, kept watching the negative comments jumping on the screen.

Bai Weiwei had guessed correctly—she had never been out in society. Previously, when she trended, it was all because she was too beautiful, so the comments were all praising her divine appearance and begging her to debut.

She had grown up smoothly like a princess, and this was the first time she was experiencing such an onslaught of negative comments.

She didn't understand why people could say such vicious things to strangers.

Liang Shi directly closed her laptop and placed the peeled shrimp beside her: "Eat first."

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "I can't eat."

Liang Shi looked at her: "We need to eat our fill to have strength to fight."

Xu Qingzhu frowned. She had gone through this vicious battle and was exhausted, not only from being betrayed by her former close friend, but also from those negative comments that fell like confetti.

They seemed light, yet every single negative comment could become the last straw that broke the camel's back.

It was Liang Shi who had been comforting her all along, saying they would definitely turn things around, that this was just a "fishing" process.

Even so, seeing those negative comments still made her feel suffocated.

It was hard to imagine what state a person would be in if they faced these things every day.

She suddenly looked at Liang Shi.

Liang Shi, who was well-versed in these tactics, had probably experienced this, hadn't she?

Liang Shi brought the shrimp to her mouth: "Hurry and eat. There's still work to do after eating."

She opened her mouth, but was so dejected that she barely opened it. When her lips closed, Liang Shi's finger was still in her mouth, though wearing a disposable glove.

But Liang Shi still felt the warmth inside her mouth.

"Hey hey hey." Sally immediately shrieked: "We're still here! Even if you're married, you can't show off like this!"

Liang Shi immediately withdrew her finger, coughing to hide her embarrassment and shyness.

Xu Qingzhu then said: "Just eat yours."

Sally pouted.

After Liang Xinhe finished eating, she asked Liang Shi: "When are you planning to start?"

Liang Shi peeled another shrimp and placed it in Xu Qingzhu's container, the action done naturally and seamlessly.

All of this fell into Zhou Yi'an's eyes, and inexplicably, the shrimp in her hand lost its flavor.

Liang Shi looked at Liang Xinhe, checking her watch: "It's about time. Right now."

This moment was 8:30 PM.

Liang Shi said that according to traffic trends on major platforms, evening was when traffic was most concentrated and explosive.

So they had to choose when online public opinion had fermented sufficiently, after they had reaped enough traffic dividends, then select the moment with the most traffic to announce the truth in one decisive blow.

Right now, the more adamant Bai Weiwei was, the faster she would fall when their evidence dropped.

8:30 PM was just the right time for all netizens to have discussion space while ensuring the vast majority would get the correct version of this melon, without negatively affecting Minghui Jewelry's reputation.

At the other end of this city, Bai Weiwei and Chen Liuying had just finished dinner in the office. They were complacently watching online comments, with public opinion completely tilted toward their side.

Bai Weiwei had also received cooperation offers from two brands and scheduled contract signings for tomorrow.

There was also an invitation for a female lead role in an online drama.

Everything seemed to be developing in a positive direction.

Bai Weiwei confidently told Chen Liuying: "Don't worry. I can definitely push you to the highest, most popular position."

For this, she could sacrifice a friend who wasn't really a friend.

Just as she was planning a beautiful future blueprint for Chen Liuying, a trending topic airborne to number one.

The topic was #Chen Liuying Dating Her Agent#

There was also #Chen Liuying Restroom Audio#

And the most critical one: #Chen Liuying Sexual Harassment#

At 8:30 PM, everything went according to Liang Shi's plan, directly airborne, exploding across the entire internet platform.

Major media outlets competed to push reports, all fighting for exclusives.

Dongheng Group and Minghui Jewelry simultaneously released public statements, announcing they would absolutely not cooperate with Chen Liuying. They even hinted that any company that cooperated with Chen Liuying in the future would become their common target.

The legal departments of Dongheng Group and Minghui Jewelry simultaneously issued lawyer's letters to Chen Liuying and Bai Weiwei, suing them for sexual harassment, malicious slander, and defamation, among other charges.

At the same time, Xu Qingzhu posted on Weibo.

@Xu Qingzhu-Blanche: I gave you a chance to reform, but unfortunately you pressed forward step by step. I'm sorry, but I don't accept any false accusations. Audio file attached.

The audio clearly contained Chen Liuying's deliberately flirtatious voice.

—I'm prettier than in the video. But why aren't you wearing that black bodysuit? It would make your figure look tighter.

—Everyone likes beautiful things. I'm just appreciating beauty. Why would that be disgusting?

The sickeningly sweet voice, blatant sexual harassment.

At the same time, photos of Chen Liuying and Bai Weiwei embracing and kissing spread across the entire internet. And Chen Liuying's superfan publicly turned against them: Chen Liuying and Bai Weiwei had been dating for half a year but still maintained a single persona to rake in money and attract fans. The two conspired to deceive fans—they deserve to die!